Getting DIII Cross Country Teams to Race Each Other

Incentive structures for interregional racing, and what more racing would and would not fix in national at-large selection. Analysis of the 2022 to 2025 selections plus the 2026 season through November 1. Prepared by Andrew Skemp.

Bottom line

1. The committee still decides a real share of bubble calls blind. In 2022 to 2025, only 32% of the key comparisons (each at-large team taken vs each region's first team left out) had ever raced each other before regionals. 13% had no direct meeting and no common opponent in the field.

2. Interregional weekend is where the evidence comes from. Most direct meetings between bubble teams happen 4 to 6 weeks before regionals. In 2026, the October 18 weekend cut the women's no-evidence picks from 21 to 5 and the men's from 9 to 5.

3. More racing alone will not make picks much more accurate. Bubble teams are separated by about 0.4 rating points, so one race orders them correctly only about 59% of the time. In simulations, pulling every contender into one national preview meet removed nearly all blind picks but left accuracy flat (84%) when picks are decided by wins and losses. Two meetings raised it to 88%, matching the committee.

4. So the package has to do two things: get bubble teams on the same start line (ideally more than once) **and** score those meetings in a way that uses the margin, not just who won. The five proposals below do both.

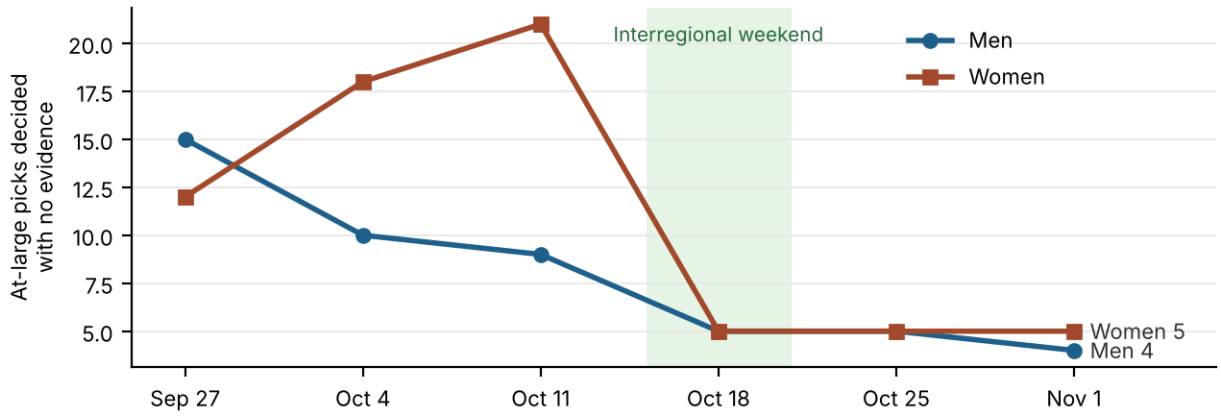
1. How big the information gap is

Season	Key comparisons	Raced each other	Shared an opponent in the field	Neither
2022	396	25%	82%	18%
2023	396	28%	86%	14%
2024	396	35%	88%	12%
2025	396	39%	94%	6%
2022-25	1,584	32%	87%	13%

Key comparison = every at-large team the committee selected paired with every other region's first team left out (cross-region pairs only), men and women. Regional results are excluded from 'raced each other'.

The trend is good: direct meetings rose from 25% to 39% and the no-evidence share fell from 18% to 6% over four years. Nearly all top-8 regional teams now race some out-of-region top-8 team (96%), but that is not the same as racing the specific teams they are compared with. The West is the outlier: only 84% of its top-8 teams raced an out-of-region top-8 team, compared with 91% in the Midwest and 98 to 100% elsewhere.

2026 so far: picks decided with no evidence, by weekend



Kolas-style selection run on each weekend's results (season-strength regional order). A 'no evidence' pick is one where the tied teams had no wins over the field, no head-to-head and no common opponents, so it fell to regional place.

2. What more racing would buy: simulation

I rebuilt each 2022 to 2025 season with extra meetings added to the real schedule, simulated their results from each team's season strength (with realistic race-day noise), then reran Kolas selection. Accuracy is measured against a **strength oracle**: the field you would pick if you knew every team's true level, keeping the regional board rule. Teams placing 1 to 8 at regionals are the invited pool; 30 simulations per season.

Schedule design	Blind picks (of 176)	Matches oracle, 60% attend	Matches oracle, all attend	Matches oracle, no race noise
Status quo (real schedules)	29	84%	84%	84%
Rotating region pairs on interregional weekend	16	85%	85%	87%
3 geographic hubs on interregional weekend	14	84%	85%	89%
2 halves (east 5 / west 5)	7	84%	85%	92%
One national preview meet	3	84%	84%	97%
Two national preview meetings	4		88%	
Three national preview meetings	5		88%	

Blind picks shown for the all-attend case. For reference, the committee's actual picks matched the oracle 88% of the time (155 of 176). 'No race noise' is an upper bound: what the same meetings would be worth if every race told the truth.

Reading it. The last column shows the information is valuable: with a perfect race, one national preview would take Kolas from 84% to 97%. Real races are noisy, and bubble teams are very close (median gap 0.41 rating points; half of bubble pairs are within 0.23 to 0.76). At that gap a single head-to-head goes to the better team about 59% of the time, so a wins-and-losses system just swaps a blind guess for a near coin flip. Two things beat the noise: **repeat meetings** and **using the margin** (how much a team won by, and against how many shared opponents).

3. Proposed incentive package

A. Losses never hurt, wins over the field count

Use Kolas-style points: a team earns a point for each team in the field it beats, and losses do not subtract. Under the current criteria, an interregional loss to a bubble rival can cost a bid, which pushes coaches to avoid each other. Under points, racing can only help.

Guardrail: Without a cap, teams could pad points by racing a lot. Count only results from meets where the team ran 5 of its top 7 (already in place), and cap at the best 4 countable meets.

B. Interregional wins are worth 1.5

A win over an out-of-region team that ends up in the field counts 1.5 points instead of 1. That pays teams to travel to the comparisons the committee needs, instead of collecting in-region wins it already has from the regional.

Guardrail: Only wins over field teams count, so beating a weak team far away earns nothing. Small enough that it does not override results.

C. NCAA hub sites on interregional weekend

Name 3 hub meets for interregional weekend (East/Metro/Niagara/Mideast, Mid-Atlantic/South/Great Lakes, Midwest/North/West) with guaranteed entry for teams ranked in the top 8 of their region by the weekly standings. The simulation shows hubs cut blind picks about in half. Rotating the groupings yearly spreads the cross-region links.

Guardrail: Travel cost is the real barrier at DIII. The ask is for the NCAA or conferences to share hub travel costs, and to put a West hub on the West Coast so the region with the least interregional racing is not penalized for geography.

D. Score meetings by margin, not just win/loss

Replace or tiebreak head-to-head W/L with a margin measure: average team-score or top-5 time gap against shared opponents and in direct meetings. This is what turns more racing into better picks: the simulation's 84% to 97% upside only shows up when meetings are read precisely.

Guardrail: Margins are less intuitive to coaches than W/L. Publish the formula and a weekly table so anyone can check it.

E. Weekly public standings plus a schedule-breadth tiebreaker

Publish Kolas standings every Monday from October 1 (like the tracker), showing each bubble team's missing comparisons. Add 'number of other regions raced' as a tiebreaker ahead of regional place.

Guardrail: Gives coaches a reason to schedule the specific rival they are being compared with, and makes the final call predictable.

Proposed tiebreak order

1) points (wins over field teams, interregional wins 1.5) 2) head-to-head among the tied teams 3) common-opponent margin in the field 4) number of other regions raced 5) regional place.

4. Caveats

The simulation draws results from each team's season strength, which is itself built from the real results, so the oracle is a model's view of 'true level', not ground truth. Attendance at hub meets is assumed (60% or 100% of each region's top 8), not predicted. Behavioral effects of points and bonuses cannot be backtested; they are design arguments. Results use the 5-of-top-7 rule throughout and the 2022 to 2025 committee selections from TFRRS.

Data: TFRRS results 2022 to 2026 (through November 1, 2026). Files: inc_partA.csv (comparison-level evidence), inc_partB.csv (simulation runs).